

Chapter 41-1

There was a direct elevator to the top floor of the mall, which was in a different direction from where Qi Tai Tai¹ was shopping.

Perhaps their intense gazes were too burning, as Qi Tai Tai suddenly turned to look in their direction. But in that instant, Liang Shi immediately turned her back and lowered her head.

It was a fear and panic carved deep into her bones.

Even her mind kept replaying that woman's gaze and smile.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu said quietly, "Let's go."

Liang Shi let out a soft breath, closed her eyes to adjust her state, then stood up and tightly held Ling Dang's hand as they walked toward the elevator.

Ling Dang was also exceptionally well-behaved.

Her little palm gently traced across Liang Shi's palm, "Auntie, your palm is so sweaty."

"It's nothing." Liang Shi's emotions were somewhat low, but she didn't want to show it in front of the child. She forced a smile, "It's because it's too hot."

"Aunt's hand is cool, let her hold yours." Ling Dang used her own hand as a medium, directly pulling Xu Qingzhu's hand over, and then their palms touched, skin against skin.

Ling Dang wasn't wrong.

Xu Qingzhu's palm was very cool, different from her own warm and sweaty palm.

Ling Dang then ran to her other side and took hold of her other hand, "Auntie, Aunt and I will both protect you."

Liang Shi was both amused and touched by her, but her heart felt warm.

She felt a bit embarrassed to hold Xu Qingzhu's hand, but was afraid Ling Dang would make a fuss, so she kept her hand suspended, only allowing a finger to occasionally brush against Xu Qingzhu's skin.

Unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu suddenly gripped her hand tightly.

Liang Shi looked over in confusion.

Xu Qingzhu smiled calmly, "Consider it helping me warm my hands."

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Xu Qingzhu was considerate of Liang Shi's feelings and didn't ask a single question about Qi Tai Tai and Qi Jiao while they were outside.

Since Ling Dang had etiquette classes on Saturday, they sent her back to the old residence after lunch and made her promise to keep secret about encountering Qi Nai Nai² and Aunt Qi Jiao at the mall.

Ling Dang raised her hand and zipped her mouth shut, "Okay."

Because she found the old residence too gloomy, Liang Shi only escorted Ling Dang inside before making an excuse about having something to do and leaving.

Qiu Zimin, hearing the news of her return, hurriedly ran out but only caught sight of the car's tail.

However, Liang Shi saw her and Sun Meirou through the rearview mirror, not knowing what they were discussing.

It probably wasn't anything pleasant, considering Qiu Zimin was frowning the entire time.

After returning home, Liang Shi was prepared to tell Xu Qingzhu about Qi Tai Tai.

But unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu didn't mention it at all and just went to the study to read.

Since Liang Shi herself hadn't figured things out either, she returned to her room to rest.

Ever since encountering Qi Tai Tai, a string in her heart seemed to be pulled taut.

That string made her entire emotional state drop, leaving her feeling dejected.

She never particularly liked being in such a state, so she would usually adjust through exercise or sleep.

Haizhou City's autumn was often rainy. Once it started, it would continue drizzling endlessly.

The morning sky that had been clear soon became overcast with dark clouds rapidly moving across the sky. The sky immediately darkened, and before long, the gentle patter of autumn rain began falling on earth.

It was just like Liang Shi's current mood.

Her entire body sank into the soft bed, watching the raindrops on the glass connect and interweave, the green branches swaying back and forth in the wind.

Such an environment was like a huge, gentle cocoon, with raindrops falling in orderly rhythm, joining with the wind to play a symphony.

It was a rhythm that could easily lull one to sleep.

Footnotes: ¹ Qi Tai Tai - "Tai Tai" is an honorific title for a married woman, similar to "Mrs." but with implications of wealth and status ² Qi Nai Nai - "Nai Nai" means grandmother, a term of address for elderly women

Chapter 41-2

Liang Shi slowly closed her eyes.

What followed was another long, heavy dream from which she couldn't wake.

The dream was filled with the same dark tones as always, a cramped room where not even a ray of sunlight could penetrate, with only a night lamp hanging on the wall.

The light was dim, and a little girl in the room crouched in the corner.

Qi Tai Tai walked in wearing a blue-green qipao¹ that would faintly glow under the dark lighting. She was smiling, but it was a smile that made one's scalp tingle.

Behind her followed a little girl. Qi Tai Tai called to her, "Jiao Jiao, aren't you the best at teaching little children?"

Qi Tai Tai lit a cigarette in this sunless room, "Go teach little sister how she should behave at home from now on."

The little girl called Qi Jiao was wearing a princess dress, with a large gash on her forehead and bruises at the corner of her mouth. She slowly walked over, crouched down to be at eye level with the little girl in the corner, "You must listen to Mama, okay? Little children who don't listen to Mama will get beaten."

Her voice was very much like the childish voices in horror movies.

Combined with the enclosed space, one could even hear the echo.

There was no light in her eyes, only numbness and barely detectable fear.

Qi Tai Tai exhaled a ring of smoke, the blue-gray smoke dispersing before her eyes.

She stood up, her high heels clicking against the cement floor, each sound like stepping on someone's heart, as if wantonly trampling on a person's heart.

Then she looked down at Qi Jiao from above, "Jiao Jiao, make little sister speak."

Qi Jiao then said, "You speak, say that you will listen to Mama."

The little girl said, "I've always listened to Mama very well. I want to go home, I don't want to stay here."

Qi Tai Tai chuckled lightly, "But your mama told you to stay here. She said you don't listen, oh."

As she spoke, she crouched down, "Didn't you break your mama's lipstick last time?"

The little girl nodded in terror, "But I didn't mean to, I already apologized to Mama."

"Does apologizing mean you should be forgiven?" Qi Tai Tai smiled, "Just like my Jiao Jiao."

"Jiao Jiao, didn't Mama tell you to make little sister listen to you? But why is she still talking back to me?" Qi Tai Tai said.

Qi Jiao immediately said, "Mama, I'm sorry, I was wrong."

"But does 'sorry' always get you 'it's okay'?" Qi Tai Tai said, then suddenly pressed the still-burning cigarette butt onto Qi Jiao's princess dress. The air immediately filled with the smell of burning fabric. Qi Jiao was in so much pain that tears streamed down, wanting to cry out loud but forcibly holding it in. She knelt on the ground, "Mama, I'm sorry."

"I should be the one saying sorry to you." Qi Tai Tai said, "Mama's Jiao Jiao, I'm sorry. Can you tell me 'it's okay'?"

"Mama, it's... it's okay." Qi Jiao said through her sobs.

"Jiao Jiao is so strong, why would she cry?" Qi Tai Tai said, once again pressing the still-unextinguished cigarette butt toward the little girl.

...

The little girl burst into loud wails.

"I want to go home." the little girl said.

But Qi Tai Tai smiled, "After a while you won't want to anymore."

That voice was like a demon's whisper: "Once you become well-behaved, you can go home."

Footnotes: ¹ Qipao - A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, typically form-fitting with a high collar and side slits

Chapter 41-3

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The dark environment once again pulled away, retreated, and spun.

Rumble—

Liang Shi suddenly opened her eyes, raised her hand to touch her forehead, and found another handful of cold sweat.

The rain outside was falling even harder, accompanied by lightning and thunder, showing signs of becoming a torrential downpour.

Before she knew it, Liang Shi had actually slept through the entire afternoon.

But this sleep felt like being pressed down by a ghost¹, leaving her entire body exhausted.

She opened her phone to check and found only a voice message from Ling Dang using Sun Meirou's account, asking if she had gotten home safely.

She replied: [Got home, just took a nap.]

Sun Meirou: [Taking care of Ling Dang must have tired you out. Sorry for the trouble.]

Liang Shi: [Not at all, Ling Dang was very well-behaved. I just like to sleep when I'm free.]

Sun Meirou: [Alright then.]

After exchanging a few more pleasantries with Sun Meirou, the conversation ended.

Liang Shi pressed her head into the pillow, trying to give herself a feeling of suffocation, then released it.

She often used this method to think about things.

After hesitating, she found Qi Jiao's phone number in her contacts, took a deep breath, and dialed.

The phone rang for a long time before the other party answered. Just like last time, it was a very gentle female voice, "Hello."

"Teacher Qi, do you remember me? I'm Liang Shi." Liang Shi introduced herself proactively, "I got your number from Rainbow last time, and we met once at the kindergarten."

Qi Jiao suddenly paused, and there was a very obvious sound of swallowing saliva.

Even through the screen, one could hear her nervousness, "Hello, is there... is there something you need?"

"I want to ask you a rather personal question." Liang Shi asked, "Have you seen me before?"

Qi Jiao: "No... no."

Her stammering revealed a significant problem.

Liang Shi immediately pressed on, "Really? When we were very young, in a dark room, you and I both experienced..."

"Jiao Jiao, eating is eating." A stern female voice came through, "If there's something to discuss, talk about it after the meal. Have you forgotten everything Mama taught you?"

Qi Jiao nervously said, "I remember, I'll hang up right away."

Then she said into the receiver, "Sorry, I need to eat. If there's anything, let's talk about it on Monday."

After saying this, she hung up the phone.

Liang Shi stared at her phone, lost in thought.

Qi Jiao... should remember those childhood events, right?

The main thing was that the feelings in that dream were too real, so real it was as if they had actually kicked her, as if fire had actually burned her.

Those pains felt as though she had truly experienced them.

This wasn't the first time she had received memories about the original body. Previously, regarding the sacrifice incident, including the stories and experiences between Zhou Yi'an and Xu Qingzhu, she had always watched from an outsider's perspective, never having such strong empathy and emotional connection.

Even with that frightening room.

It was limited to just fear.

But Qi Tai Tai terrified her. Just hearing her voice made her scalp tingle.

Liang Shi sent Qi Jiao a text message: [Teacher Qi, see you Monday.]

She still needed to figure this matter out, and Qi Jiao was the best breakthrough point.

Just after sending the text, that familiar mechanical voice entered her mind: [Ding dong! Congratulations to the host for completing the additional task: doing handicrafts with Xu Qingzhu. This little system is deeply gratified this time, but unfortunately, the host failed to complete the task of accumulating 60 luck points in a short time, which would have awarded five luck points, but but but but host you were really close! Just a little bit more and you would have touched the hope of victory, sigh. However, compared to before, this is still great progress.]

[Due to your completion of the additional task, your misfortune points have now returned to zero, luck points accumulated to fifty-four. The reward of 49,999 yuan has been deposited into your account, please check. PS: It hasn't even been a month, and you've already accumulated half the luck points! We're proud of you. If only your progress could be a bit faster.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Her progress wasn't slow!

[Ding dong! Due to the host's good performance, you have gained one opportunity to ask little system a question. Opportunity knocks but once oh!]

Liang Shi didn't hesitate and directly asked, "Did I come here when I was little? Why am I so familiar with Qi Tai Tai?"

System: [...]

After two seconds of silence, that eerie mechanical voice said: [Sorry host, heavenly secrets cannot be revealed.]

Liang Shi: "...?"

"Didn't you say I could ask?" Liang Shi was speechless.

System: [I also didn't say I would definitely answer.]

Liang Shi: "Then what can you answer?"

System: [...For example, the plot line might be slightly collapsing now.]

Liang Shi was surprised: "What?"

Didn't you say it wouldn't collapse?

System: [Forget it, I'll come clean.]

Liang Shi: "?"

System: [I just wanted to kindly remind you that the Liang family's real daughter² is about to start looking for her family.]

Liang Shi: "..."

I'm tired, let it all be destroyed.

Footnotes: ¹ Ghost pressing down - A Chinese expression for sleep paralysis, the feeling of being unable to move while sleeping ² Real daughter - In Chinese web novels, refers to the biological daughter who was switched at birth, as opposed to the adopted/fake daughter